geopolitical moves. In the end, though, the close China–Pakistan relationship is more effect than cause: it resulted from the India–China conflict, not the other way round. India and China are also divided by a number of other differences – growing Chinese influence among India's other neighbours in South Asia; India's coalition building with Japan and Vietnam in China's backyard; their diplomacy in other parts of the world and in multilateral forums; international status-seeking by both powers; India's huge trade deficit with China; and Chinese dam-building on the Yarlung Tsangpo/Brahmaputra river. These are important elements of the troubled relationship, but again they are more effect than cause. They are not the fundamental causes of their conflict. Rather, they have become additional points of friction driven by the four more basic causes.

This is a book about the India–China conflict examined through the two countries' perceptions of each other, their differences over the border and Tibet, their partnerships with the Great Powers, and their growing power asymmetry. The two countries do also have a record of cooperation, primarily in preserving military stability along the borderlands. Despite serious confrontations in 1967, 1975, 1986–87, 2013, 2014, 2015, 2017, and 2020, the total number of Indian battle-deaths in these eight episodes is just over a hundred (the Chinese figures are not public).[2] For a 'live' border quarrel between such large countries, this is a small number. On the other hand, India and China have had five major confrontations in the last decade alone, after nearly twenty-five years of military stability, confrontations that could have escalated. In a paper I published on India's China policy in June 2018, I concluded with the thought that India was 'faced with the possibility of more Doklams around the corner' – this after the 73-day stand-off between the two militaries near the trijunction of India, China, and Bhutan in 2017.[3] The Ladakh crisis of 2020 was much more than a Doklam, but the prediction was correct in so far as it suggested that relations were increasingly brittle and prone to crisis. The 2020 confrontation may be resolved more or less peacefully, but it is a good bet that there will be more Ladakhs.